6
Global Communities of Multilingual Language Users

Many linguistic anthropologists would agree with the statement that a group of people who are set apart socially from others somehow will probably be set apart linguistically as well – and vice versa: a group of people set apart linguistically from others will also probably be set apart socially. Yet, the specifics of how, why, and even whether this generalization actually holds true in particular cases must be explored through empirical research, and this sort of research requires a clear notion of what constitutes a meaningful social or linguistic community. Can such communities be identified along the lines of age or hobby, as the cartoon that appeared at the start of Chapter 1 (Figure 1.1) suggests is the case with young people and golfers? Scholars have debated this question for decades, centering initially on the term made popular by many sociolinguists, "speech community." In recent years, however, many linguistic anthropologists have shifted to some alternative terms, such as linguistic community, speech area, speech network, and, especially, *communities of practice*. These concepts, some scholars believe, allow for research that treats communities not as static, pre-existing entities but as emergent groups that are fluid and overlapping, crossing social and often international boundaries.

This chapter provides an overview of the challenges involved in identifying communities of language users as objects of linguistic and social analysis. The chapter seeks to (1) encourage readers to question

Living Language: An Introduction to Linguistic Anthropology, Third Edition. Laura M. Ahearn.
© 2021 John Wiley & Sons, Ltd. Published 2021 by John Wiley & Sons, Ltd.

some of their taken-for-granted notions about the nature of such communities; (2) uncover some of the assumptions and unstated social theories that often underpin such concepts as "speech community"; and, (3) introduce readers to some of the most interesting research that furthers our understanding of the relationship between linguistic practices and social groups in global and multilingual contexts.

Defining "Speech Community"

You might think it would be fairly easy to define the term "speech community." After all, what could be so difficult about making sense of a term that pretty clearly refers to a group of speakers, right? Complications set in, however, once we start trying to specify exactly what we mean by "speech" and by "community." It turns out to be quite tricky to identify the boundaries of a speech community and to specify what the members of that community have in common. Consider the questions that can be raised regarding just these three aspects of the term: (1) the size and location of the community; (2) what is shared by members of the community; and (3) the type of interactions the community members might or must have.

Size and Location of the Community

- How large or small can (or must) a speech community be? Is a family too small? John Haviland (2013) provides an example of one family that might constitute a unique speech community – some of its members use an emerging homesign (or sign) language and some speak a Mayan language with some Spanish sprinkled in. If a family could form its own speech community, could a couple? How about one individual? Is a "community" consisting of one person too small to constitute a speech community? And is the entire population of a country, or even the earth, too large to form a single speech community?
- Can the concept be used to describe entities that are not defined by static physical location, where, for example, "membership can be experienced as part of a nation-state, neighborhood, village, club, compound, on-line chat room, religious institution, and so on" (Jacquemet 2019; Morgan 2004:4)?

- Should speech communities be conceptualized as nested within or overlapping one another, with individuals belonging to multiple speech communities simultaneously?

What Is Shared by the Members of a Speech Community?

- Must everyone in a speech community speak the same language or dialect at the same level of fluency?
- Do speakers of the same language or dialect automatically constitute a speech community?
- Do people who use American Sign Language (ASL), or one of the many other sign languages in the world, constitute one or more "speech" communities?
- How important are shared attitudes toward language and evaluations of linguistic practices (i.e., language ideologies) for determining speech community membership?
- Must members of a speech community be aware that they are members of such a community?

The Type of Interactions that Speech Community Members Have

- Must speech community members have face-to-face interaction, at least virtually? If so, how frequently? Or could they interact only in writing and still be a "speech" community?
- Might people involved in online or other electronically mediated interactions, such as a class that meets via Zoom, constitute a virtual or literacy-based speech community?
- Might there be different kinds of membership in a speech community – central vs. peripheral, for example? In other words, might speech communities be more accurately portrayed as networks with varying density (Milroy 2002b)?

Linguists, sociolinguists, and linguistic anthropologists have answered these questions in different ways. The concept of speech community, while initially defined by linguists such as de Saussure (1916) and Leonard Bloomfield (1933) in the first part of the twentieth century, began to be more widely used and more carefully defined in the 1960s

and 1970s when sociolinguists and linguistic anthropologists such as Dell Hymes, John Gumperz, and William Labov were looking for ways to link linguistic practices and social groups more systematically for the purposes of their research. Decades earlier, as was discussed in Chapter 5, anthropologists such as Franz Boas, Edward Sapir, and Benjamin Whorf had posited an integral relationship between language, thought, and culture. Hymes, Gumperz, and Labov, each in his own way, attempted to use the concept of speech community to clarify the specific nature of this relationship and to reject the approach of de Saussure, Chomsky, and other linguists. In an influential passage from his textbook *Foundations in Sociolinguistics*, for example, Hymes stated emphatically that "the natural unit for sociolinguistic taxonomy (and description), however, is not the language but the speech community" (Hymes 1974:35). Hymes's focus on beliefs, values, attitudes, and ways of speaking within a community draws explicitly on Sapir's work (1974:46) and departs from the approach of linguists because the unit of analysis for Hymes is "a social, rather than linguistic, entity" (1974:47).

Gumperz, too, explicitly noted the ways in which his approach departed from that of formal linguists such as de Saussure and Chomsky. Whereas in formal linguistics, Gumperz noted, the object of analysis is "a particular body of linguistic data abstracted from the settings in which it occurs" (2001[1968]:43), scholars, such as sociolinguists and linguistic anthropologists who are interested in studying language use in actual social contexts, must choose a very different object of analysis, Gumperz argued, and must situate their study in a very different "universe":

> This universe is the speech community: any human aggregate characterized by regular and frequent interaction by means of a shared body of verbal signs and set off from similar aggregates by significant differences in language usage. Most groups of any permanence, be they small bands bounded by face-to-face contact, modern nations divisible into smaller subregions, or even occupational associations or neighborhood gangs, may be treated as speech communities, provided they show linguistic peculiarities that warrant special study. (2001[1968]:43)

Gumperz did not assume that members of speech communities all speak the same way – or even the same language. In fact, Gumperz has

always been centrally concerned with multilingual and multidialectal communities in his research. Though members of such communities might not all share a style, a dialect, or even a language, they nevertheless share a "verbal repertoire" (2001:50). "Regardless of the linguistic differences among them," he notes, "the speech varieties employed within a speech community form a system because they are related to a shared set of social norms" (2001:44).[1]

Thus, in Gumperz's famous formulation, we see several requirements that many other scholars have also adopted in their definitions of the term "speech community":

1 Frequent interaction among the members must occur.
2 The members of the speech community must share a "verbal repertoire," even though they may not all speak the same style, dialect, or even language.
3 The members of the speech community must also share a set of social norms regarding appropriate language use – what linguistic anthropologists now call "language ideologies."

This third criterion – that of shared language ideologies – is also a central component of the definition of speech community made famous by William Labov, a well-known sociolinguist. Labov conducted a study in the 1960s of linguistic variation on the Lower East Side of New York City and concluded that the heterogeneous nature of that community was not at all unusual or problematic. "The speech community is not defined by any marked agreement in the use of language elements, so much as by participation in a set of shared norms," Labov noted in an oft-quoted passage (Labov 1972b:120–121, cited in Patrick 2002:586). So, while New Yorkers in Labov's study did not pronounce "ing" or "r" the same way, for example, Labov nevertheless contended that they evaluated speech in the same ways, as stigmatized or high status, for example. This shared evaluation of linguistic practices therefore created a single speech community in New York's Lower East Side during the 1960s, according to Labov.

Another scholar who has argued for the usefulness of the concept of speech community, while also attempting to redefine it, is linguistic anthropologist Debra Spitulnik. In her ethnographic study of radio discourse in Zambia, a multilingual society in which dozens of languages are spoken, Spitulnik wonders, "[D]oes it even

make sense to speak of a speech community across the nation-state when there is no one common language?" (2001:96). Spitulnik's research investigates whether the concept of speech community can be applied to a situation in which there are millions of people who never interact with or even know one another, and in which the linguistic knowledge they share is at best limited. In such a situation, the relevance of the speech community concept is clearly questionable – and yet Spitulnik argues that it can indeed be a useful concept when studying the effects of mass-mediated communication such as radio. The same conclusion might be drawn regarding other mass media, such as television, movies, or the internet, because all of these forms of communication can be characterized by a high frequency of interaction in the "vertical" sense, meaning a great deal of exposure to mass media. Thus, Spitulnik argues, radio programs in Zambia – an extremely popular type of mass-mediated communication in that country – provide common reference points for people in their everyday conversations. Zambian radio programs are also a source for linguistic innovations such as new idiomatic expressions, styles of speaking, or even identities. Laura Kunreuther (2010) similarly found that call-in radio programs in Nepal shaped listeners' subjectivity in important ways. Small snippets of talk are taken out of their original radio contexts and reinserted into ordinary social interactions, thereby indexing speakers as "modern" or conversant with various types of acronyms associated with national and international organizations. This type of decontextualization and recontextualization is extremely common with all forms of mass-mediated communication – and, in fact, with all forms of communication in general.

With regard to the "shared linguistic knowledge" component of many definitions of speech community, therefore, Spitulnik argues that Zambian radio programs are an important source for common reference points and subtle but important linguistic connections that can be forged across linguistic, ethnic, regional, and even national boundaries (2001:113; cf. Morgan 2004:5–6). The concept of speech community can, Spitulnik maintains, be productively refined by incorporating a consideration of factors such as frequency of media consumption and large-scale exposure to a common media source.

Alternatives to the Concept of "Speech Community"

Some researchers have attempted to substitute alternative terms for "speech community" because of the difficulties in defining exactly what members of a given speech community allegedly share and in determining exactly how they interact. In addition, since the concept emerged from the field of sociolinguistics without any particular connection to broader social theory, some scholars have found it to be, at best, insufficient and, at worst, misleading. Mary Bucholtz (1999:207), for example, lists six inadequacies embedded in the concept of speech community:

1 Its tendency to take language as central.
2 Its emphasis on consensus as the organizing principle of community.
3 Its preference for studying central members of the community over those at the margins.
4 Its focus on the group at the expense of individuals.
5 Its view of identity as a set of static categories.
6 Its valorization of researchers' interpretations over participants' own understandings of their practices.

For all of these reasons, Bucholtz and others (e.g., Jacquemet 2019) have turned to alternative concepts to help them shed light on the linguistic and social practices they study.

Speech Areas

Jean Jackson's (1974, 1983) oft-cited work on the Vaupés territory, a tropical rainforest that falls partly in Colombia and partly in Brazil, challenges the notion of speech community in some profound ways and provides an alternative to it.[2] Among the indigenous groups who lived in this area during the time of Jackson's research in the 1960s and 1970s, all people were multilingual, speaking languages that cut across the Tukanoan, Arawak, and Carib language families. Everyone spoke at least three languages fluently, many spoke four or five, and some understood as many as ten (1974:55). The groups lived in multilingual communities composed of longhouses. An important component of each individual's identity was membership in a particular

"language aggregate" – in other words, the patrilineal descent group based on the language of his or her father. And the main rule for marriage, according to Jackson, was "linguistic exogamy" – the requirement that a person not marry someone from his or her own language aggregate.

As Jackson notes, this complex linguistic situation calls into question the utility of the concept of speech community. On the one hand, she argues, the entire central Northwest Amazon, including both the Colombian and the Brazilian territory, can be thought of as a single multilingual speech community (1974:55) because the people in this area share cultural and religious practices. Even though they do not all speak the same language, they share an understanding of how language should be used in daily social life. But Jackson suggests that it might be more appropriate to consider the Vaupés area to be a "speech area," a term she relates to the German concept of *Sprechbund*.[3] In this speech area, Jackson claims, "All Indians share rules for speech, even though some Indians' verbal repertoires do not overlap" (1974:55). Then, she continues, if the entire Vaupés area is a speech area, the individual longhouses or villages could be considered its actual speech communities. Still, these much smaller groups of people will always be multilingual because of the rule to marry outside of one's language aggregate, so Jackson notes that ethnographic study of these kinds of communities will almost certainly deepen and possibly challenge existing notions of speech community and multilingualism.

Speech Networks

Some scholars assert that it is not sufficient merely to identify the boundaries of a community of language users; it is also important, they argue, to characterize the nature of the connections and interactions that members of speech communities have with one another. Sociolinguist Lesley Milroy, for example, draws on social network analysis to understand the influence of social ties of various strengths and types on language use and language change over time (Milroy 1987, 2002a, 2002b). According to this approach, individuals might be members of numerous speech networks simultaneously and/or sequentially over the course of their lives. The memberships of the various networks to which they belong might or might not overlap or be nested within one another in some way. Individuals' ties with

others in these networks will also vary in the following ways (Milroy 2002b:550–551):

- *Strong or weak ties*. In networks with strong ties, individuals have strong personal relationships, perhaps involving kinship or close friendship. In networks with weak ties, individuals are connected merely by acquaintanceship or some other relatively distant relationship.
- *Multiplex or uniplex networks*. In networks with a "multiplex" structure, individuals are connected to one another in multiple ways. For example, a woman might work in the same office as her cousin to whom she is very close socially, making that woman a co-worker, a relative, and a friend. In networks with a "uniplex" structure, individuals are connected to one another in only one way.
- *High density or low density*. In high-density networks, many of the people any one person knows will also know one another. In low-density networks, the opposite will be true.

For a particular person ("X" in Figures 6.1 and 6.2), the experience of being in a strong, multiplex, high-density network (such as the one pictured in Figure 6.1) will be very different from being in a weak, uniplex, low-density network (such as the one pictured in Figure 6.2). The implications for linguistic practices are also significant. Speech networks of the former sort that feature close-knit social ties appear to facilitate the retention of dialects or languages, whereas speech

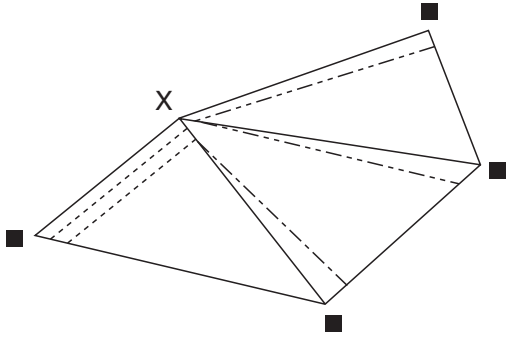


Figure 6.1 Strong, multiplex, high-density network with individual "X" at center. *Source*: Adapted from Milroy (2002b:551) with permission from John Wiley & Sons.

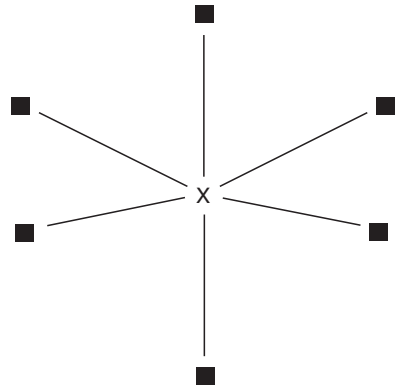


Figure 6.2 Weak, uniplex, low-density network with individual "X" at center. *Source*: Adapted from Milroy (2002b:551) with permission from John Wiley & Sons.

networks of the second sort can lead to the loss of regional dialects or minority languages (Milroy 1987, 2002a, 2002b; Trudgill 1996). Milroy has also suggested that differences in network structure are correlated with socioeconomic class: "Different types of network structure seem to be broadly associated with different social classes; loose-knit networks with the socially and geographically mobile mainly middle classes, and close-knit ties with very low status and very high status speakers" (2002b:566–567).

Despite these sorts of claims, the relationship of speech networks to one another and to a broader conceptualization of society as a whole remains unspecified or underspecified in this sort of network analysis because, generally, scholars who employ it focus instead on less abstract, more micro-level social interactions. Some researchers consider the micro-level focus of network analysis to be a strength because it means that the approach is theoretically compatible with any number of macro-level social theories, but others fault network analysis for lacking a more explicit theorization of power and social difference at the macro level (cf. Milroy 2002b:550; Patrick 2002:583).

Communities of Practice

Within linguistic anthropology, the most influential alternative to the concept of "speech community" is the notion of "community of practice." Originally proposed by Jean Lave and Etienne Wenger (1991)

in their co-authored book, *Situated Learning: Legitimate Peripheral Participation*, the concept of "community of practice" has been groundbreaking and paradigm-shifting not just in linguistic anthropology but in fields as disparate as education, government, and business (Hughes et al. 2007:2–4). *Situated Learning* makes use of the concept of community of practice in order to describe the socially embedded nature of learning. William F. Hanks, a linguistic anthropologist, describes the significance of Lave and Wenger's approach to learning in the foreword to their book: "Rather than asking what kinds of cognitive processes and conceptual structures are involved, they ask what kinds of social engagements provide the proper context for learning to take place" (Hanks 1991:14). And, just as learning takes place not just in an individual's head but in the social interactions in which that individual takes part, so too does language reside not just in an individual's head but in real-life social interactions, making the concept of community of practice equally applicable to the study of language use as a form of social practice (Hanks 1991:13).

As a practice-based approach to the process of language socialization, the concept of community of practice was formally introduced to linguistic anthropology by Penelope Eckert and Sally McConnell-Ginet in their widely cited 1992 article in the *Annual Review of Anthropology*.[4] In that piece, they define the concept of community of practice as follows:

> A community of practice is an aggregate of people who come together around mutual engagement in an endeavor. Ways of doing things, ways of talking, beliefs, values, power relations – in short, practices – emerge in the course of this mutual endeavor. As a social construct, a community of practice is different from the traditional community, primarily because it is defined simultaneously by its membership and by the practice in which that membership engages. (This does not mean that communities of practice are necessarily egalitarian or consensual – simply that their membership and practices grow out of mutual engagement.) (1992:464)

The three main criteria for identifying a community of practice, according to Wenger (1998:73ff), are (1) mutual engagement; (2) a joint enterprise; and (3) a shared repertoire. Examples of communities of practice might include members of a family, students in an in-person or online linguistic anthropology class, faculty members in a particular

department, a road construction crew, a baseball team, members of a religious congregation, or regulars at a neighborhood bar. Individuals can be members of multiple communities of practice simultaneously or sequentially over a lifespan. A major advantage of the concept of community of practice is that, unlike many sociolinguistic studies that use a concept of speech community based on pre-existing and abstract characteristics such as age, sex, or geographic residence, the concept of community of practice helps researchers produce practice-based, ethnographic studies that illustrate the emergent nature of communities and the inseparability of language from actual social contexts. In such studies, language is just "one of many social practices in which participants engage" (Bucholtz 1999:210). "The community of practice takes us away from the community defined by a location or by a population," Eckert and McConnell-Ginet write. "Instead, it focuses on a community defined by social engagement" (1998:490).

Some wonderful studies have been conducted by scholars describing various communities of practice. Eckert and McConnell-Ginet, for example, identify two main communities of practice in a Michigan high school pseudonymously called "Belten High," at which Eckert conducted ethnographic and sociolinguistic fieldwork in the 1980s (Eckert and McConnell-Ginet 1995, Eckert 1989). The "Jocks" comprise a school-oriented community of practice whose participants engage in extra-curricular activities and embody middle-class values. The "Burnouts" resist schooling and embody working-class values. Eckert and McConnell-Ginet demonstrate how these two class-based communities of practice "define the landscape of identities at Belten" (1995:477). Through close analysis of these students' linguistic and social practices, Eckert and McConnell-Ginet demonstrate how broader social categories such as class, gender, ethnicity, and adulthood are crafted and contested through the everyday interactions of students at the high school. Differences in vowel pronunciation, dress, and behavior characterize the members of these two communities of practice – and yet they are all members as well of an overarching community of practice whose members value "coolness" (even while defining it differently) and consider the Jock-Burnout opposition to be the defining one for the school (1995:478).

Mary Bucholtz's research also involves adolescents, but instead of studying high schoolers who seek to be "cool," she studies "nerds" – those students who define themselves in opposition to Jocks,

Burnouts, and any other "cool" group (Bucholtz 1999:211; 2001, 2007). Like Eckert and McConnell-Ginet, Bucholtz finds the concept of community of practice ideal for looking at the complexities of identity formation in teenagers. By carefully analyzing linguistic and social practices, Bucholtz is able to distinguish between two different ways in which nerds construct their social identity. Negative identity practices are those that individuals employ to distance themselves from a rejected identity, such as avoiding slang and nonstandard pronunciation, or avoiding fashionable attire. Positive identity practices are those in which individuals engage in order actively to construct a chosen identity, such as proudly displaying knowledge or engaging in skillful word play (1999:211–212). Rather than analyzing nerds according to pre-ascribed identity categories such as age, gender, race, or class, Bucholtz, through her illuminating application of the concept of community of practice, shows how these categories are emergent in the actual social interactions of the individuals in complex and sometimes contradictory ways, thereby linking micro and macro levels of social and linguistic analysis.

Within anthropology as a whole thus far, the concept of community of practice has been utilized most frequently by scholars in the area of the anthropology of education and the study of language and gender. Some scholars have suggested that the concept lends itself most appropriately to the study of novices and experts, making it especially appropriate for research on adolescents who are learning how to act in culturally appropriate ways in schooling or other contexts, but others have argued that the concept is equally useful in studying any social group (Meyerhoff 2002:539–540).

The concept of community of practice is not without its detractors, however. Some scholars have criticized the approach for lacking a sufficiently robust theorization of power (e.g., Hughes et al. 2007), while others have lamented the lack of attention given to language (both verbal and written) by scholars who analyze communities of practice in fields such as business or education (e.g., Barton and Tusting 2005). Nevertheless, the concept remains a promising alternative to speech community as a way to recognize the emergent and socially embedded nature of all linguistic interactions.

Whichever terms scholars use to designate the groups of language users they study – speech community, speech area, speech network, community of practice, or something else altogether, such as "publics"

(cf. Morgan 2004; Muehlmann 2014) – they have an obligation to their readers to define their terms clearly. From the perspective of linguistic anthropology, any of these terms could generate insightful research as long as the researcher incorporated an awareness of the importance of the multifunctional and multimodal nature of language, an understanding of the way it indexes social identities and relations, an analysis of the intertwining of social and linguistic practice, and an acknowledgment of the influence of language ideologies on social categories (and vice versa).

Multilingual and Transnational Linguistic Practices

Given the complex diversity of many linguistic communities and their speakers, it is essential – no matter which terms researchers use in their analysis – to recognize the importance and commonality of multilingualism and transnational linguistic practices. As Marco Jacquemet writes:

> To analyze diasporic social networks we need a unit of analysis that can account for both contiguous and noncontiguous interactions without clear boundaries. This new conceptualization should enable us to understand communication as a virtually boundless heteroglossia of juggling voices and partial identities emerging from a multiplicity of interconnected networks of social relations. (Jacquemet 2019:54)

As examples of the interconnected networks of individuals engaged in "transidiomatic practices" that Jacquemet describes, consider these residents of central New Jersey whom I have met in my classes at Rutgers University or in my daily interactions around town.[5]

Mary, a second-year college student, was born in the United States to parents who had immigrated to this country from Vietnam, so Vietnamese was her first language. By the time she entered kindergarten, however, she was also quite proficient in English, though she lacked knowledge of everyday idioms. Because Mary was extremely shy, her kindergarten teacher thought she was less fluent in English than she actually was, so she advised Mary's parents to speak to her at home in English only. Her parents did this, and the result was that by age eight, Mary could no longer speak Vietnamese fluently. In Mary's extremely diverse, multilingual high school, teachers used to patrol the hallways and reprimand students who were speaking languages other than English. Mary's passive understanding of Viet-

namese remains good, but her conversational ability is poor. Mary wrote the following in a language autobiography essay for one of my classes: "From the age of five, I became a victim of the 'tyranny of the standard' (Morgan 2004:15) imposed by all educational institutions and became a victim of my own language insecurities."

Miguel, a senior in college, was born in the United States, but both of his parents are from Mexico. Miguel has a sister who is four years older than he is and a brother who is five years younger. When Miguel was born, his mother was still learning English, so the main language spoken in the home was Spanish. Once Miguel started school, he learned English as well but retained his Spanish fluency. His sister also became completely bilingual in Spanish and English. By the time their younger brother was born, however, their mother's English had improved greatly, and the main language spoken in their home shifted to English. As a result, Miguel's younger brother understands Spanish somewhat but cannot speak it. When the family gets together, they speak a mixture of Spanish and English. His sister, who is married to another bilingual speaker of Spanish and English, speaks only English to her children, so they are now monolingual.

Sarah, a bank teller in her twenties, has grandparents who immigrated to the United States from Ireland and Germany, but they spoke Gaelic or German in the home too rarely for Sarah's parents to become fluent in either of these languages, so Sarah was raised in a monolingual English-speaking household. Throughout junior high and high school, Sarah took Spanish for her foreign language requirement, but she never gained more than a basic proficiency. Even that diminished throughout college and beyond because her university did not require students to take any foreign languages, and Sarah chose not to continue taking Spanish. Nevertheless, she speaks English in very different ways to her friends, her parents, and her work colleagues (including her boss).

Aaron, who was born in the United States in the 1950s, had four grandparents who immigrated to the United States from various places in Eastern Europe. All of them spoke Yiddish, the language of Jews who lived in shtetls (small villages) in Eastern Europe at the turn of the last century, and also had some proficiency in English. Aaron's parents both learned Yiddish as children but became completely fluent in English. English was the main language spoken in Aaron's home while he was growing up, though his parents did code-switch into

Yiddish sometimes when their parents were around or when they wanted to prevent their children from understanding what they were saying. As a result, Aaron acquired a little bit of passive knowledge of Yiddish. After college, Aaron traveled to Israel, becoming fluent in Hebrew and living there for six years. Upon his return to the United States, however, he married a woman who did not speak Hebrew or Yiddish, so the language they speak in their home, aside from a smattering of Hebrew, Yiddish, and a couple of other languages – and the only language spoken by their daughter – is English.

Min, a fourth-year student in a joint BA/MS/PhD pharmacology program, was born in China with profound hearing loss. Min's mother spent many, many hours teaching her to lip read and speak Mandarin Chinese intelligibly. When Min was nine years old, the family immigrated to the United States, and Min spent the next several years learning how to lip read and speak intelligible English. When she entered middle school, she was offered a chance to learn American Sign Language (ASL), and within just a few months Min felt as though she had "found" her native language. No longer did she miss what people said when they were turned away from her, and no longer did she have to struggle to be understood. By learning ASL, Min had also become a member of a new "speech" community – the Deaf community (note the intentionally and proudly capitalized "D") – with its own cultural and linguistic practices and different norms for communication and interpretation. While Min prefers this speech community to all others, she still lip reads often and participates regularly in many non-Deaf communities of practice.

When **Douglas** was a toddler, his parents took him to the Dominican Republic for a year while they did volunteer work there. Though he was completely bilingual in Spanish and English by the end of his time there, he quickly lost his fluency in Spanish upon the family's return to the United States, but since reaching adulthood he has tried to regain his Spanish proficiency in order to interact with Spanish-speaking customers in his store. And, after Douglas married and had children of his own, he and his wife, who is a monolingual English speaker, decided to send their two children to a bilingual Spanish-English summer camp to help them acquire at least a little bit of Spanish.

How typical are these individuals? How common is it, in other words, for someone to speak more than one language fluently? What sorts of speech communities do they belong to? And is multilingualism

(whether in individuals or societies) a "good thing" or a "bad thing"? Language ideologies abound concerning the prevalence and desirability of multilingualism. Some of these views are legitimate personal or political opinions, but others are factually mistaken beliefs. Many people, for example, consider multilingualism to be unusual, especially in the United States. Linguist John R. Edwards refutes this misconception:

> To be bilingual or multilingual is not the aberration supposed by many (particularly, perhaps, by people in Europe and North America who speak a "big" language); it is, rather, a normal and unremarkable necessity for the majority in the world today. A monolingual perspective is often, unfortunately, a consequence of possession of a powerful "language of wider communication", as English, French, German, Spanish, and other such languages are sometimes styled. (Edwards 1994:1; cf. Romaine 2001:512)

While it is clear that bilingualism (the ability to speak two languages) and multilingualism (the ability to speak two or even more languages)[6] are common, estimates regarding the precise number of people who speak two or more languages around the world are hard to come by because it is surprisingly difficult to determine how many languages are spoken in total, and what even counts as a language. This is the case for several reasons. First, the number of languages spoken in the world is changing all the time because so many languages are dying out (an issue we will explore further in a later chapter). Second, it is estimated that one quarter of the world's languages are spoken by fewer than a thousand people, each making them difficult to find, identify, and study (Lewis, M.P. 2006). Third, globalization has led to increases in migration and developments in communication technologies that allow for transnational flows of ideas, languages, and asymmetries, creating "creolized, mixed idioms of polyglottism" – that is, complex and creative mixtures of languages (Jacquemet 2005:263).

And finally, there are no universally accepted criteria for distinguishing between a "language" and a "dialect." The difference between a way of speaking that gets labeled a language and a way of speaking that gets labeled a dialect often comes down to politics, culture, and history (Lippi-Green 1997). The following famous saying is often attributed to linguist Max Weinreich, though he himself reportedly attributed it to an unnamed high school teacher who attended some of his lectures in the 1940s: "A language is a dialect with an army and

a navy."[7] In other words, a way of speaking that is labeled a "language" often has the political support of a nation-state in the form of an edict pronouncing it a national or official language. As a result, linguistic variants are often designated as languages or dialects based not on the amount of overlap they have in vocabulary or grammar, or on mutual intelligibility among their speakers, but on the basis of geopolitics.

For example, Swedish and Norwegian are labeled as two separate languages (the official languages of Sweden and Norway, respectively), and yet their speakers have no trouble understanding one another (Childs 2006). Similarly, though the written scripts of Hindi and Urdu differ, there is a great deal of overlap in spoken Hindi and Urdu, but because of their association with the two different nation-states of India and Pakistan (respectively), and their different literary and cultural histories, Hindi, and Urdu are often referred to as separate languages. The Cantonese and Mandarin "dialects" of Chinese, on the other hand, are not mutually intelligible when spoken, though their scripts do overlap. And, prior to the break-up of the former Yugoslavia, Serbo-Croatian was considered a single language with separate Eastern and Western "dialects," but after Serbia and Croatia became independent, each declared its language to be separate and different from the other. Even though the speakers of Serbian and Croatian generally have little trouble understanding one another, the governments and citizens of the two countries often claim that they are two completely different languages (Greenberg 2004:1–3), as does the government of Bosnia and Herzegovina for the allegedly separate language of Bosnian (sometimes called Bosniak or Bosniac), which was also formerly called simply Serbo-Croatian. Clearly, when it comes to distinguishing between languages and dialects, considerations of politics, history, ethnic identity, religion, culture, and indigenous rights take precedence over technical linguistic considerations.

There is also confusion and controversy surrounding the term "dialect" because it is often used to describe only those ways of speaking that are of lower status in a given society. In actuality, everyone speaks (at least one) dialect, but speakers of standard dialects – the ways of speaking used by mainstream newscasters, highly educated national figures, and others – tend not to recognize that they, too, speak a dialect; they, too, have an "accent" (Lippi-Green 1997).

In addition to dialects, language researchers also use the term "register" to connote "a linguistic *repertoire* that is associated, culture-

internally, with particular social practices and with persons who engage in such practices" (Agha 2004:24; emphasis in the original). Examples of registers include what people metalinguistically label as "polite language," "geek speak," "informal speech," "God talk," "girl talk," or "slang." Even monolingual individuals can generally code-switch among several different registers. Asif Agha explains: "An individual's *register range* – the variety of registers with which he or she is acquainted – equips a person with portable emblems of identity, sometimes permitting distinctive modes of access to particular zones of social life … Differences of register competence are thus often linked to asymmetries of power, socioeconomic class, position within hierarchies, and the like" (Agha 2004:24, emphasis in the original; cf. Agha 2007).

Because it is difficult to determine with any certainty what should be labeled a dialect as opposed to a language, and because factoring in the existence of registers makes the calculation even more challenging it is, therefore, virtually impossible to arrive at a definitive count of the world's languages. Estimates range from 5,000 (Romaine 2001:512) to over 7,100 separate languages, with many more variants usually labeled as dialects. These languages are not distributed equally across the countries of the world; linguistic diversity is far greater in some areas than others. For example, K. David Harrison notes that "the 65 inhabited islands of Vanuatu (together about the size of the state of Connecticut) support 109 distinct tongues in a population of just 205,000 people. That is one entire language for every 1,880 speakers" (2007:11). Even in countries where there is far less linguistic diversity, however, there are almost always multiple languages spoken. In this sense, then, every country in the world could be said to be multilingual.

In the United States, for example, the US census in 1980, 1990, and 2000 asked several questions about languages spoken in the home and levels of proficiency in these languages, as well as in English.[8] Beginning in 2010, instead of including these questions in the decennial census, these same questions began to be asked every year in the US Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS). According to the responses on the most recent ACS, 21 percent (roughly 62 million people) of the respondents aged five and over reported that they spoke a language other than English in the home. This figure has increased from 11 percent in 1980 to 14 percent in 1990, to 18 percent in 2000.

More than half of these latter respondents reported speaking Spanish (approximately 38 million people). Of the 21 percent (one in five people) in the US who said they spoke a language other than, or in addition to, English in the home, 58 percent said they spoke English "very well," 19 percent said "well," 15 percent spoke English but "not well," and 7 percent said they could not speak English at all (Ryan 2013:3).

How likely are more recent immigrants to the US to learn English over time, compared to immigrant groups in the past? In other words, is English becoming less dominant, or will contemporary immigrants and their descendants learn English at roughly the same rate as past immigrants and their descendants? Answering this question is not easy because of the nature of census data, the complexity of language use, and the variation across different regions of the United States. The portion of the US population speaking a language other than English has definitely been increasing over the past few decades, but according to one group of scholars, recent groups of immigrants from Asia are learning English at the same rate as European immigrants a century ago, or even more quickly, resulting in a third generation (those whose grandparents immigrated) that almost always speaks only English (Alba et al. 2002:480). Among Spanish-speaking immigrant groups, the rate appears to be somewhat slower, but this is largely dependent upon whether a second-generation bilingual person marries another person bilingual in Spanish and English (an example of "endogamy," or marrying within one's social group) and whether they reside in a community in which Spanish is commonly spoken. Endogamy alone is not enough to ensure that third-generation individuals will still be able to speak Spanish, but endogamy along with residence in a community in which Spanish is supported can increase the chances that a third-generation individual will be able to speak at least some Spanish. Nevertheless, Alba et al. report that "in all the groups that we could examine, the majority of third- and later-generation children speak only English at home, which implies that, with probably limited exceptions, they will grow up to be English monolinguals who have, at most, fragmentary knowledge of a mother tongue" (2002:480). This research suggests that English will most likely remain the overwhelmingly dominant language for the foreseeable future. As Dennis Baron notes, "A look at what the 2000 Census tells us about language use in the United States reveals that English continues to be the dominant, and in many cases, the

only language of the United States and confirms that warnings about the decline of English are unwarranted" (Baron n.d.:1; cf. Baron 1990:199).

Obtaining an accurate count of the number of people worldwide who speak more than one language fluently is even more challenging than ascertaining this statistic for the United States. Nevertheless, we do know that multilingualism in individuals is, as Edwards noted above, quite common. According to some estimates, half the world's population is probably multilingual, and multilingual individuals are present in practically every country in the world (Grosjean 1982:vii, cited in Romaine 2001:512). And, in certain areas, such as the Vaupés region of Colombia described earlier in this chapter, many people speak four or five languages, and some speak up to ten (Jackson 1974:55). The myth – a very powerful language ideology – of the necessity of "one nation, one language" goes back at least several hundred years to German philosophers such as Johann Gottfried Herder (cf. Bauman and Briggs 2003; Jacquemet 2005:260; Silverstein 1996), but it is belied by the reality of so many multilingual nations and individuals around the world. Though conflicts are sometimes blamed on language differences, there is no evidence in most cases to support the assertion that the language differences themselves have led to problems. Instead, such conflicts are almost always in actuality about something else, usually "about fundamental inequalities between groups who happen to speak different languages" (Romaine 2001:532).

In some nations, multiple languages are accorded "national" or "official" status. In India, for example, Hindi (written in Devanagari script) is the only "official" language, but English, the language of government proceedings when India was a colony of Britain, continues to have special constitutional status and is the language used for the authoritative texts of all laws (Government of India, Ministry of Law and Justice 2007). In addition to Hindi and English, there are many other languages accorded recognition in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution of India, amended in 1992 and 2003 to add a number of other languages (cf. Booth 2009a). Currently, the Eighth Schedule lists 22 official languages other than English.[9] And while the Official Language Resolution of 1968 states that "it is the duty of the Union to promote the spread of the Hindi Language and to develop it so that it may serve as a medium of expression for all the elements of

the composite culture of India," it also states that "it is necessary in the interest of the educational and cultural advancement of the country that concerted measures should be taken for the full development of these languages" – in other words, for the "full development" of all 22 of the languages listed in the Eighth Schedule (Government of India, Ministry of Home Affairs 1968).

In actual practice, the choice of which language to use in schools, for civil service exams, or in court proceedings remains controversial in India, and language movements have arisen from time to time to argue for the official recognition of one language or another (cf. Booth 2009a; LaDousa 2005, 2014), but the example of multilingualism in India – the largest democracy in the world, with over a billion people – proves that linguistic diversity is not antithetical to national unity. In fact, multilingualism is an integral part of India's national identity and a daily fact of life for many of its residents. Suzanne Romaine states:

> The average educated person in Hyderabad [a city in southern India] may use Telugu at home, Sanskrit at the temple, English at the university, Urdu in business, etc. He or she may also know other varieties of Telugu, or Kannada, Tamil, or Malayalam for reading, dealing with servants, or other specific purposes. Many south Asians have active control over what amounts to complex linguistic repertoires drawn from different languages and varieties. In societies such as these, multilingualism is not an incidental feature of language use, but a central factor and an organizing force in everyday life. In most parts of India, monolingualism would be problematic relative to the norms and expectations about the number of languages and varieties a person needs in order to manage the everyday things a normal person has to do. (2001:517)

Diglossia, Code-Mixing, and Code-Switching

In multilingual communities, the languages, dialects, or registers that are spoken are often linked to social hierarchies. In other words, linguistic practices index status, and language ideologies develop as a result. Some ways of speaking tend to get labeled prestigious, while others are stigmatized. Since all languages, dialects, and registers are rule-governed, there is nothing inherent in them that makes some "better" than others linguistically; these sorts of judgments are made for social, cultural, political, or historical reasons. For example, in some

contexts in the United States, speaking Spanish is looked down upon, and people who speak Spanish in public are sometimes stigmatized. (Many English-Only laws are based on these language ideologies.) In countries such as Mexico, however, it is Spanish that is often accorded higher status compared to indigenous languages such as Mexicano or the many Mayan languages. These sorts of language ideologies are complex, however, and must be studied in their actual social contexts.

When individuals within multilingual communities are themselves multilingual (as opposed to communities in which monolingual speakers of different languages live side by side but are not themselves multilingual), the ways in which these multilingual people switch from language to language can vary in interesting ways. The communities themselves can differ in terms of stability – that is, whether the community continues to be multilingual over a long period of time, as Jackson (1974, 1983) documented for the multilingualism in the Vaupés area of the Amazon, or whether the multilingualism transforms into monolingualism, possibly also resulting in the death of one of the languages involved (Garrett 2004:53; Romaine 2001:522). The communities also vary in terms of the number of languages spoken and the extent to which people shift from one to another on a daily basis. Scholars use terms such as *diglossia*, *code-switching*, and *code-mixing* to describe these linguistic practices, which can refer not just to switching from language to language but also from dialect to dialect or register to register. Therefore, some researchers argue that these processes of shifting between and among language variants are more common than previously recognized and could even be said to occur in every community. The more distinct the language varieties, however, the easier the shifting will be to study and the more likely it will be that the speakers will be aware of the practice and accord it special social significance. For these reasons, diglossia, code-switching, and code-mixing have most commonly been researched in communities in which individuals speak two or more languages (Woolard 2004:74).

Diglossia

Diglossia refers to a situation in which "each language or variety in a multilingual community serves a specialized function and is used for particular purposes" (Romaine 2001:519). Though the term has

been defined in different ways and applied to many different types of linguistic communities, diglossia typically describes a fairly stable situation involving the compartmentalized use of two "codes" (languages or dialects) that are hierarchically related to each other. One code is labeled as the high status (H) code and the other the low status (L) code. The H code tends to be used in domains and activities in which there is an official purpose, such as giving a public lecture, writing, schooling, or broadcasting. The L code, in contrast, tends to be confined to informal and domestic domains involving the interaction of friends and family. In the initial formulation of diglossia by Charles Ferguson (1959), the two varieties were required to be related to each other linguistically, as, for example, classical and vernacular versions of Greek or Arabic are, but in subsequent analyses, scholars have tended to widen the scope of the term to include more than two variants of one language, or two or more completely different languages altogether (Garrett 2004:54). The common thread evident in most research on diglossia, however, remains the condition of compartmentalization within specific social domains, and most scholars who use the term study language varieties that are associated with high or low prestige. While individuals may switch from one to another of the language varieties, in diglossic situations these shifts most often occur as individuals move from one social setting to another – for example, from home to the workplace.

Code-Switching

The sorts of shifts from one language variety to another that occur in a single social setting are often considered to be examples of *code-switching*, "an individual's use of two or more language varieties in the same speech event or exchange" (Woolard 2004:73).[10] Both linguists and linguistic anthropologists have sought to demonstrate the ways in which these switches are systematic rather than random, with linguists focusing on grammatical regularities and linguistic anthropologists focusing on the social meanings and identities that the code-switching indexes. For linguistic anthropologists, code-switching is an ideal subject for exploring all four of the discipline's key terms outlined in Chapter 1. Shifts between language varieties will always be *multifunctional* – that is, they will always have multiple potential social meanings and functions. Through regular linguistic and social

practice, the shifts will come to be associated with some meanings and identities more than others – that is, shifting from one language variety to another will come to *index* particular social relationships, meanings, or hierarchies more than others. Opinions and attitudes about these ways of speaking and the social dynamics they index will develop and, in turn, these *language ideologies* will influence people's linguistic and social practices in the future. Thus, code-switching lends itself beautifully to study by linguistic anthropologists.

A compelling example of an illuminating analysis by a linguistic anthropologist of code-switching is Jane Hill's (1995) article, "The Voices of Don Gabriel: Responsibility and Self in a Modern Mexicano Narrative." Hill closely examines a story told by Don Gabriel, who was said to be the last speaker of the indigenous language of Mexicano (the strongly preferred local term for the Uto-Aztecan language also known as Nahuatl or Aztec) in his small town near the Yucatan Peninsula of Mexico. As part of a general interview about his life experiences, Don Gabriel was asked if he had ever suffered any accident or serious illness. "No. No, no accident, no, only they murdered my son," Don Gabriel replied, at which point he launched into a 17-minute narrative about his son's death (Hill 1995:98). Hill's complex analysis looks at many aspects of this narrative, including the multiple voices Don Gabriel uses to tell his story, techniques such as reported speech, intonation, and dysfluencies (hesitations, self-corrections, or other departures from normal fluency). Most relevant to our discussion here is Hill's analysis of Don Gabriel's code-switching between Mexicano and Spanish, for these two languages index Don Gabriel's moral assessments of the two speech communities: "These represent the fundamentally opposed ideological positions of peasant communitarianism and the economics of reciprocity in the Mexicano-speaking community on the one hand, and the pursuit of individual profit in the Spanish-speaking world of the marketplace on the other" (Hill 1995:116). Repeatedly throughout the narrative, when Don Gabriel refers to the individualistic, profit-making nature of the Spanish-speaking business world with which his son was involved, his narrative contains dysfluencies that indicate, Hill argues, his discomfort with that set of moral values. In addition, when Don Gabriel needs to make use of Spanish words to describe business, he incorporates them into the voices of others through reported speech or in various other ways makes it clear that his own moral position is

"firmly grounded in the peasant communitarian value of reciprocity" (Hill 1995:109). In this analysis, then, we see how a close examination of code-switching can shed light on cultural meanings, moral judgments, and social hierarchies.

Another linguistic anthropologist who has studied code-switching is Bonnie Urciuoli (1991, 1996), whose research on the shifts between Spanish and English by Puerto Ricans in New York City has led to a better understanding of when boundaries between languages (or dialects, registers, etc.) are perceived as firm and distinct as opposed to when the boundaries can be fuzzier or more indistinct. As noted in the summary of Urciuoli's work that appeared in Chapter 1, socioeconomic status is an important consideration when studying the social aspects of code-switching. When the economically disadvantaged Puerto Ricans Urciuoli studied were with other equally poor neighbors who were black, racial and ethnic differences took a back seat and the boundaries between Spanish and English became fuzzy, resulting in the Puerto Ricans' switching back and forth fluidly between Spanish and English with their black neighbors. In contrast, when the Puerto Ricans were with white, middle-class people, especially if these people were in positions of authority (such as social workers or school administrators), the boundaries between English and Spanish were perceived to be more rigid because the stakes were typically much higher in these sorts of interactions. Thus, Urciuoli states, "I argue that the bilingual's sense of language boundary, English or Spanish, depends on the dynamics of relationships, on race, class, and gender as much as on ethnicity" (1996:295).

Code-Mixing

The question of boundaries between language varieties becomes even more complex when considering shifting that occurs mid-sentence, or even mid-word. Scholars generally use the term *code-mixing* to describe the sort of shifting that involves a greater sense of hybridity and inter-mixture between two or more ways of speaking. An example of this sort of code-mixing can be seen in a common practice among many US Peace Corps volunteers I knew in Nepal who would take a Nepali verb form such as *bokne* ("carry," usually referring to the carrying of a basket on one's back using a tumpline across one's forehead) and add to it an English ending such as "ing" to create

a hybrid Nepali-English word in an otherwise English sentence, as in this hypothetical but typical example:

I saw her *bokne-ing* the heavy firewood, so I offered to help.

[*Eng*: I saw her carrying the heavy firewood, so I offered to help.]

Another even more hybrid mixture of Nepali and English can be seen in this actual example recorded by Chelsea Booth[11] of a remark made by a young woman in Darjeeling to her friend Laxmi:

Laxmi, if you see him, *kurā garne u sanga*, *just sodhne*, "Do you know Anoop?" *Thīk*?

[*Eng*: Laxmi, if you see him, have a conversation with him, just ask, "Do you know Anoop?" Okay?]

Controversies and language ideologies abound regarding the multifunctionality of this sort of mixing. Some people consider such hybrids as Spanglish (the combination of Spanish and English) or Sheng (the combination of Swahili and English) to be impure and detrimental to the speakers, while others consider such mixing to be creative, possibly even constituting a new language altogether, called a "monolect" or a "fused lect" (Meeuwis and Blommaert 1998; Auer 1999). Peter Auer's (1999) typology consists of three kinds of shifting, best conceived of as a continuum from what he calls "codeswitching"[12] (CS) at one end of the spectrum, through "language mixing" (LM) in the middle, to "fused lects" (FL) at the other end of the continuum. Though Auer himself does not present the continuum visually, it could be represented as in Figure 6.3.

Auer defines code-switching as those shifts from one code to another in which "the contrast between one code and the other (for instance, one language and another) is meaningful, and can be interpreted by participants, as indexing (contextualizing) either some aspects of the situation (discourse-related switching), or some feature of the code-switching speaker (participant-related switching)" (Auer 1999:310). Language mixing, in contrast, is a more thorough intermixing of codes, to the point that it is the alternation between two

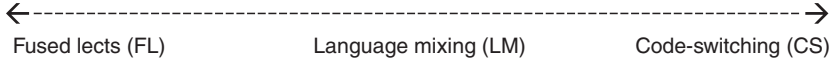


Figure 6.3 Peter Auer's continuum of codeswitching, language mixing, and fused lects.
Source: Auer (1999:328). Reproduced with permission from Sage and P. Auer.

codes that "itself constitutes the 'language'-of-interaction" (1999:315). The shifts in language mixing, according to Auer, do not involve the same sort of indexicality and shifts in footing that are involved in code-switching; indeed, the shifts back and forth between the two codes in language mixing do not seem to have any specific discursive function, except insofar as the mixing of the two codes in and of itself might index a particular social identity or set of meanings. At the far end of Auer's continuum is the phenomenon of "fused lects," which he defines as the development of a single code "AB" from two previously separate codes, "A" and "B." The main difference between language mixing and fused lects is one of grammaticalization; certain elements are stabilized or regularized, and there is less fluid shifting back and forth. Moreover, with a fused lect "AB," speakers may be unable to speak either "A" or "B" fluently. The new fusion may or may not become recognized as a "language" in its own right, depending on which language ideologies prevail. Despite the linguistic dexterity evident in code-switching, language mixing, and fused lects, speakers of these linguistic varieties may even be subject to racialized judgments that they are "languageless" (Rosa 2016) because of a "culture of monoglot standardization" (Silverstein 1996).

Some researchers, such as Laada Bilaniuk (2005), study shifts between codes – between Ukrainian and Russian in Bilaniuk's case – that span Auer's entire spectrum. These different types of Ukrainian/Russian mixtures are known as *surzhyk* and are generally stigmatized. In her research in Ukraine, Bilaniuk identified five types of Ukrainian/Russian mixtures that depended on factors such as the urban or rural residence of the speakers or the historical time period (pre- or post-Soviet, for example). Bilaniuk locates the five language mixtures along the Auer continuum from fused lects (FL) to language mixing (LM) to code-switching (CS) – and various combinations of these practices. So, for example, she identifies an "Urbanized Peasant" variant of *surzhyk*, which falls between fused lects (FL) and language mixing (LM) on Auer's continuum, and a "Post-Independence" variant that falls between language mixing (LM) and code-switching (CS) on Auer's continuum. In Bilaniuk's careful study, the complexities of linguistic practices and the accompanying language ideologies bring to life the multiple linguistic manifestations and social implications of various kinds of code-switching.

Heteroglossia

To help illuminate the complicated multilingual global landscape, some scholars have coined terms that are intimidating tongue-twisters – and yet some of the terms are worth learning and using because they can help us reframe or reorient our study of multilingualism. Heteroglossia, for example, is a term made popular by the Russian literary critic Mikhail Bakhtin many decades ago. It refers to the many dialects, registers, and languages that there are in society. Though Bakhtin was mainly analyzing language within novels and other literary genres, much of what he said about language in these contexts has been found to be very helpful for social scientists interested in linguistic practices in real-life social settings.[13] Heteroglossia, in particular, is a concept that sheds light on the complex and fascinating co-existence in any given social context of multiple ways of speaking – whether they are different languages, dialects, or registers (however defined). In "Discourse in the Novel," an essay originally published in the 1930s, Bakhtin argued that language in actual social life is always stratified in multiple ways. Stratification creates different language varieties along the lines of genre, such as the different ways of writing for a popular newspaper vs. "high" literature; along the lines of profession, such as different ways of speaking among lawyers, doctors, politicians, or teachers; and along other socially significant dimensions, such as age, education level, or elite status (Bakhtin 1981a:289–290). While Bakhtin never mentions the term "indexicality," his writings nevertheless describe the processes through which linguistic practices index social identities. In a famous passage, part of which formed the epigraph to Chapter 1 of this book, Bakhtin states:

> As a result of the work done by all these stratifying forces in language, there are no "neutral" words and forms – words and forms that can belong to "no one"; language has been completely taken over, shot through with intentions and accents. For any individual consciousness living in it, language is not an abstract system of normative forms but rather a concrete heteroglot conception of the world. All words have the "taste" of a profession, a genre, a tendency, a party, a particular work, a particular person, a generation, an age group, the day and hour. Each word tastes of the context and contexts in which it has lived its

> socially charged life; all words and forms are populated by intentions. Contextual overtones (generic, tendentious, individualistic) are inevitable in the word. (1981a:293)

There are two opposing forces in language, according to Bakhtin: the "centralizing" (or "centripetal") force used by highly authoritative entities such as governments that want to unify the language and make a unitary, standard way of speaking appear to be obligatory and natural, and the "decentralizing" (or "centrifugal") force that leads to ever greater stratification and ever more variation in socially charged ways of speaking (Bakhtin 1981a:272; Bakhtin 1981b:67). We can see these centralizing and decentralizing forces at work linguistically in many places around the world and also when we look at the global linguistic situation as a whole. In many cases, globalization has led to centralization and standardization in the form of greater use of dominant languages such as English, but it has also led to high rates of migration, resulting in greater decentralization and linguistic diversity in more communities than ever before (cf. Romaine 2001:530–532). Bakhtin was one of the first scholars to appreciate these opposing forces and the social complexity of language.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we explored the concept of "speech community" and some of its alternatives, as well as some of the many facets of multilingualism, both at the individual and societal level, and placed these phenomena in the context of communities that exist within an increasingly "globalized" world. Code-switching and code-mixing between or among languages, dialects, or registers provide fascinating opportunities for research on the individual and social dimensions of multilingualism. At a more macro level, studying the stigmatization or valorization of different languages and language policy within various nation-states can shed light on complex political and cultural relationships and values. Studies that consider both the micro-level linguistic practices of actual people and the macro-level workings of language politics within or across communities or societies have the best chance of adequately analyzing the complexities involved in multilingual communicative interactions.